

what price car they can afford or how to work a baby into their budget. But even worse, often they don't really know how much they are spending.

In the majority of marriages, the wife ends up being the bookkeeper. She's the one who is usually responsible for keeping the books balanced, writing the checks and paying the bills. That doesn't mean that husbands should not be involved. They should, and must be. A couple should develop their plans together and work together. But there can be only *one* bookkeeper in the home. When there are two bookkeepers, you'll have two messes.

Typically, in over 80 percent of the families we counsel, the wife is the bookkeeper. Usually the wife has more time and pays more attention to detail. Therefore, she makes the better bookkeeper. But in order to do it well, she must know how to do it. Later I'll discuss how to balance a checkbook and how to develop a budget. But for now, take my word that unless you do, you won't have peace in your marriage.

MINIMUM NUMBER 4: GET EDUCATED

"The naive believes everything, but the prudent man considers his steps" (Proverbs 14:15). Most naive people are ignorant. Ignorant does not mean stupid; it means unknowledgeable. For instance, many couples borrow money without understanding the actual interest rate. Their primary concern at the time is, "How much are the monthly payments?" Others borrow more money than they can repay because they have no system of budgeting. They literally don't know where their money goes each month or how much credit their income can support.

I once assumed that almost everyone knew how to balance a checking account. I quickly discovered that was an erroneous assumption. Many people have only a vague idea of how much is in their bank accounts and have never balanced their accounts. They write checks and fail to record them in their ledger; they pay overdraft charges on checks written on insufficient funds; or they simply accept the bank's statement as totally accurate.